

OVERVIEW



This chapter introduces the core rules for playing *Dune: Adventures in the Imperium*.

As the rest of the rules in the other chapters build on the mechanics found here, it's valuable to have a decent understanding on how all this works. Each section within this chapter starts with a brief primer on what that section describes, which is then elaborated upon and described in full.

DICE

Dune: Adventures in the Imperium uses a single type of dice to resolve the actions a character may attempt and the situations they may face: twenty-sided dice, often referred to as a **d20**. Most of the time more than one die is rolled at once: these dice are collectively referred to as a **dice pool**. The number of dice being rolled are noted as **Xd20**, where X is the number of dice being rolled, so **2d20** means two twenty-sided dice are rolled.

RE-ROLLS

Some situations or abilities allow a character to re-roll one or more dice. When re-rolling dice, you choose the dice you wish to re-roll. You then roll those dice again, and the new results replace the old ones, even if the new result is worse.

Some situations allow you to re-roll a specific number of dice, while others allow an entire dice pool to be re-rolled. You may always choose how many dice you wish to re-roll, up to the maximum listed—in essence, you can always choose not to re-roll a die if you wish to keep that result.

Once you've re-rolled a die, you may not re-roll it again: the second result stands, even if you have another ability that lets you re-roll.

CHARACTERS

This chapter will refer to abilities and details which are described fully across this chapter, but in order to avoid too much page-flipping, we've provided a basic overview here:

- ✧ **Traits:** A character has two or more traits, which serve as basic descriptions of who the character is. These interact with the rules in the same way as other traits.
- ✧ **Skills:** A character has scores in five broad skills—Battle, Communicate, Discipline, Move, and Understand—ranging from 4 to 8. These determine how capable a character is at a certain type of activity and are used as part of a character's target number when they make a skill test.
- ✧ **Focuses:** A character has focuses for several of their skills. Focuses describe areas of specialization and expertise within each skill. If a focus applies to what a character is doing, it increases the chances of scoring critical successes when making a skill test.
- ✧ **Drives:** A character has scores in five drives—Duty, Faith, Justice, Power, and Truth—ranging from 4 to 8. These show how strongly a character believes in these facets of life and are used as part of a character's target number when they make a skill test.
- ✧ **Drive Statements:** A character's highest drives also have statements associated with them. When a character wishes to use a drive as part of a skill test, they must check to see if the statement agrees or conflicts with the action being taken. If a character's drives agree with their actions, they receive bonuses, while if their drives conflict with their actions, they may be hindered.
- ✧ **Talents:** A character's talents are distinctive special abilities setting them apart from other people. The distinctive powers of the Bene Gesserit and the accelerated thought processes of Mentats are both types of talents.
- ✧ **Assets:** Described fully in **Chapter 6: Conflict** and **Chapter 7: Assets**, a character's assets represent the tools and resources they have at their disposal, which can be invaluable in overcoming adversity.

SCENES AND TRAITS

All adventures in ***Dune: Adventures in the Imperium*** are broken down into scenes, which the gamemaster is responsible for setting up. Once the gamemaster has set up a scene, the players may take whatever actions they desire, and once there's nothing else they can, or wish to, do in that place, the scene ends. Scenes also include descriptors called traits, which point out anything important about the scene's time or place, or the characters or objects within it.

A scene is the basic building block of an adventure, just like books and movies are broken into scenes. A scene is a place and time involving a specific set of characters, in which an exciting or dramatic event occurs, usually moving the story forward.

At the start of a scene, the gamemaster will inform you where your character is, what's going on, and anything else useful or important you should know. There'll always be a reason behind this scene, driven by what happened in the scenes before it: perhaps you came here because of a clue left by an assassin, or because you're looking for a specific person. Once the gamemaster has finished setting the scene, you and your fellow players can ask questions about the situation and choose for your characters to do things within the scene:

move around, talk to other people, or otherwise take actions. Once you've reached a point where you can't do anything further toward your goal, or you've gained a new goal that requires you go somewhere else, the scene ends, and a new one begins.

During a scene, your decisions are important; the choices you make have an impact upon the world around your character, and you'll have to face the consequences of those choices. The gamemaster can shape the events in a scene, too, by spending Threat and through the actions of non-player characters, but this is normally in response to your choices and those of your fellow players.

For the gamemaster, part of setting up a new scene is describing the **traits** which apply to that scene. Traits



describe the notable and interesting details about a place, time, person, or object, sort of like keywords for other rules to interact with. Each trait is a single word or a short phrase that describes a single detail about the thing it belongs to. A trait is always both true and important: a trait goes away if it stops being true or important.

As a player, traits influence the kinds of things your character can try and do, and how difficult those actions are, but you can also interact with traits more directly, adding, removing, or altering the traits in a scene as your actions change the situation. How you can do this is explained later in the chapter.

THE EFFECT OF TRAITS

In practice, traits have a simple impact on your character's actions: if a trait is relevant to an action being attempted, it makes the action possible or impossible, or it makes the action easier or harder. Multiple traits can be applied to a situation at once, whether canceling one another out or adding to one another. Some especially intense or potent traits may actually be multiple identical traits added together: a battlefield might be shrouded in *Smoke*, or visibility might be reduced by *Thick Smoke 2*, with the number indicating that it counts as two traits.

In practice, this is easy to apply. Each trait can be placed into a simple statement, such as one of those below, and if that statement makes sense, then it applies. If it doesn't make sense, then it doesn't apply.

- ❖ Because I am [personal trait], this activity is...
- ❖ Because of [situation or location trait], this activity is...
- ❖ Because I have [equipment trait], this activity is...

The end of each of those statements is either 'easier', 'harder', 'possible', or 'impossible'. At the simplest level, that's as far as the gamemaster needs to go with trait: if the statement ends with 'easier', reduce the Difficulty, if the statement ends with 'harder', increase the Difficulty. If the statement ends with 'possible', then the activity can be attempted while the trait applies, while if it ends with 'impossible', then it can't be attempted while that trait applies.

It's also worth remembering that if a trait makes an action impossible, that doesn't necessarily mean you can never attempt that action: rather, it may mean that the action is impossible *unless you change the situation to make it possible*.

Remember also that assets are also traits. If one can apply to a scene it works just like any other trait. Having a knife makes a combat easier than fighting unarmed. Having blackmail evidence makes an attempt to blackmail a target possible. For the most part, assets (especially in architect play) are what makes the test possible.

Example: Kara Molay, heir to her House, is trying to negotiate a new trade deal with a spice merchant at a large social gathering. As the merchant is known as a fair trader, Kara's player believes her 'Honorable' trait may apply. She tells the gamemaster "Because Kara is honorable, it will be easier to make a deal with the merchant." The gamemaster agrees and reduces the Difficulty of the test.

As many traits as you like can be added to a scene, but the gamemaster can veto any they don't believe are appropriate to the situation, or will do what the player wants. As traits can be used to cancel each other they should be brought into play one at a time, giving the other side the option of playing a trait to counteract it. This build up of traits to finalize the total modifier of the action is something that should be played out and described.

Example: Revisiting the example above this is how the scene might play out with a more complex interchange of traits.

Kara attends the party to try and speak to the spice merchant. The gamemaster describes the scene and gives the scene the trait 'Convivial'. As Kara makes her approach the gamemaster tells her player that as Kara doesn't know the spice merchant, he won't do business with her without a proper introduction. Kara doesn't have time to try and make another test to convince someone to make such an introduction. So Kara asks to invoke the Convivial trait to make the attempt possible. It's a friendly party, and so the gamemaster allows Kara to use the trait to approach informally and introduce herself. In this way the trait makes the test possible.

The gamemaster then declares the merchant is 'Distrustful 2' upon meeting Kara. Kara can use her Honourable trait to mitigate this a little and drop Distrustful to just 1. But this means the test to negotiate is one step more difficult.

Kara wants better odds so decides to use her blackmail evidence asset, making it apply to the merchant. She whispers a few hints into the conversation and the merchant goes pale. The Difficulty penalty is removed.

Kara could leave it there, but might spend Momentum to create another trait to make the upcoming test easier. She might even bring in her knife as an asset to physically threaten the merchant, but that might be a little much! The gamemaster might also use Threat to add more traits to make things harder again, such as the merchant having friends or not being easily frightened.

SKILL TESTS

Whenever your character takes action, and there is doubt in the outcome—failure is a possibility, or the result might depend on how well they succeed—the gamemaster asks you to make a skill test. When you make a skill test, the gamemaster tells you how difficult the skill test is, expressed as Difficulty.

Select one of your **skills** and one of your **drives** and add their scores together to make a **target number**. Then, roll two d20s:

- Each die that rolls equal to or under that target number is a **success**.
- Each die that rolls a 1 is a **critical success**, worth two successes.

If your character has a **focus** that would help in that action, then any die that rolls equal to or less than their skill is a critical success instead. Count your successes, and if you scored successes equal to or greater than the Difficulty, your character has passed the skill test and achieves what they set out to achieve.

DIFFICULTY

For many skill tests, as long as you achieve one success you have succeeded at the action you are attempting. However, some actions are simply more complex than others, or can be made more difficult by circumstances. While it may be a challenge to pick a lock, it is more of a challenge to do so in the rain, blindfolded with an enemy agent about to attack you.

When a player asks to make a skill test, the gamemaster should determine the Difficulty of the task, which is rated 0–5. The player must get at least as many successes on the skill test result as the Difficulty to achieve the task. If they fail they may still opt to ‘succeed at a cost’. The

WHEN TO ROLL

Much of the time, when playing *Dune: Adventures in the Imperium*, you simply describe what you want your character to do, and the gamemaster decides whether it’s possible and what happens next. Most actions your character takes should be so simple that you don’t need to use the rules.

However, there are sometimes actions that aren’t so simple to resolve. Most commonly, these fall into one of three categories:

- The action is difficult or dangerous, or both.
- The action is directly opposed by someone else.
- The action is simple, but how well you succeed is important.

In these situations, the gamemaster asks you to make a skill test, following the process described below.

WHAT’S AT STAKE

Both you and the gamemaster should have a clear idea of what a skill test is for, and what happens if the skill test succeeds or fails. In general, one of the following is likely to be true:

- The skill test is an attempt to achieve something: if you pass, you get the result you desire; if the skill test fails, you don’t get that.
- The skill test is to avoid or resist a danger. In this case, a pass means that you avoid some or all the danger, while failure means that you suffer the full effects of the danger you sought to avoid.
- The skill test is to achieve something, but there’s something at stake as well. If you pass, you get what you wanted and avoid the consequences, while failure means that you suffer the consequences instead, or must choose to face the consequences if you want to achieve your goal.

The gamemaster should inform you of the potential outcomes for success or failure before you attempt a skill test. Your character is assumed to be capable enough to know the likely outcomes for their actions.



gamemaster should determine the Difficulty as fairly as possible based on the task at hand. However, the gamemaster may then spend Threat to increase the set Difficulty to represent further complications to the task.

The gamemaster may allow a test to be made with a Difficulty of 0. This sort of test is made when the character cannot really fail, but the quality of their action may still apply. This might be staking out an enemy facility to get an idea of the security, scouting out terrain before a battle, or mingling with the guests of a soiree to pick up rumors and gossip. As usual, any successes scored above the Difficulty generate Momentum, and so such tests can grant a boost to the player's Momentum pool before they initiate a conflict, representing their preparations and planning.

In general, the Difficulty should follow the following guidelines:

SIMPLE (DIFFICULTY 0)

- ✧ Nudging open a stuck door
- ✧ Following an unaware subject in the dark in a place you know intimately
- ✧ Asking for a simple favor
- ✧ Deceiving a simple-minded subject
- ✧ Investigating a subject of common knowledge

AVERAGE (DIFFICULTY 1)

- ✧ Overcoming a simple lock
- ✧ Following an unaware subject in the dark
- ✧ Asking for a significant favor from a friend
- ✧ Deceiving a trusting subject
- ✧ Investigating private but not secret knowledge

CHALLENGING (DIFFICULTY 2)

- ✧ Overcoming a complex lock
- ✧ Following a suspicious subject in the dark
- ✧ Asking for a favor that costs the benefactor something minor
- ✧ Deceiving a wary subject
- ✧ Investigating confidential or hidden knowledge

DAUNTING (DIFFICULTY 3)

- ✧ Overcoming a complex lock in a hurry
- ✧ Following a suspicious subject during the day
- ✧ Asking for a difficult favor from someone you already owe
- ✧ Deceiving a deeply suspicious subject
- ✧ Investigating knowledge that has been actively hidden by a powerful faction

DIRE (DIFFICULTY 4)

- ✧ Overcoming a complex lock, in a hurry, without the right tools
- ✧ Following a suspicious subject in the daytime in streets they know well
- ✧ Asking for a complicated or expensive favor
- ✧ Deceiving a subject who considers you an enemy
- ✧ Investigating knowledge whose very existence has been hidden

EPIC (DIFFICULTY 5)

- ✧ Overcoming a complex lock, in a hurry, without the right tools, during a battle
- ✧ Following a subject who knows they are being followed, knows you personally, and knows the streets
- ✧ Asking for a dangerous favor from a stranger
- ✧ Deceiving a your worst enemy
- ✧ Investigating knowledge whose very existence has been hidden for centuries

WHAT ARE YOU DOING, AND WHY?

When you're attempting a skill test, the choice is yours as to which skill and which drive you want to use. However, this isn't simply a case of picking the biggest numbers.

First, select your skill. This should be fairly obvious, as your skill relates directly to what you're doing. Usually the gamemaster determines the skill to be used, but the player is allowed to suggest alternatives.

When you've selected your skill, check to see if any of your focuses apply to the action. For both skill and focus, the gamemaster may overrule your choices and suggest something else, or they may prompt a particular choice in advance. However, you always get to make a choice and try to justify why it fits the situation: the choice of skill is defined by what it is you're choosing to do.

Second, select your drive. This reflects your character's motivation and drive behind the action—why they are doing what they're doing. Some of your drives come with a statement. These describe the most important aspects of what your character believes, providing both advantages and limitations. To select which drive to use, look at the character's drive statements and pick the one most appropriate to the situation. This is not necessarily the most advantageous, as drives can often be a disadvantage in some circumstances. The drive linked to the drive statement you choose is the one you must use for the test. If multiple statements are appropriate, choose which of those drives to use. If none of the statements apply, choose one of the character's drives that does not have a statement to use in the test.

When you wish to use a drive, you must check to see if the statement agrees with the action.

- ✧ If the drive statement agrees with the action, then you can use that drive on this skill test. In addition, you are allowed to spend a point of **Determination** (described on p.157) on that skill test if you wish. You cannot spend Determination if the drive you're using has no statement.
- ✧ If the drive statement clashes with the action—the drive doesn't support the action, or the action goes against the drive—then the gamemaster may offer you a point of Determination and ask you to make a choice about the drive: either comply with the drive, or challenge it. If you comply, you suffer an immediate

complication on the action you're attempting, which could include being unable to carry out the action. If you challenge the drive, you can use it in the skill test, but the statement is crossed out *immediately* after the skill test is resolved, and you can't use that drive until you've recovered it—you now doubt how you feel about that drive, and can no longer rely on it. If you don't want either of those options, you may refuse the point of Determination and choose a different drive.

If the drive you're using has no statement, then you may choose to use it, without restriction. In these cases, the following guidance may be helpful when determining which to use:

- ☞ **Duty:** Does the action relate to your responsibilities or obligations? Often easy to justify when acting for your House.
- ☞ **Faith:** Does the action rely upon trusting in others, an organization, or a higher power? Often useful when relying on empathy and wisdom.
- ☞ **Justice:** Does the action relate to matters of morality, of simple right and wrong, or to the law? Often useful (ironically) in acts of deceit.
- ☞ **Power:** Does the action rely on you having authority, status, or power over someone, or does it relate to your ambitions? Often useful in conflict.
- ☞ **Truth:** Does the action seek to uncover secrets, or to convince someone of something, whether true or false? Often useful in investigation.

Tests can also be augmented by the players spending points of Momentum or Determination, or hindered by the gamemaster spending points of Threat. A result of 20 creates a complication for the character making the test. This represents an additional problem, similar to a trait, that makes further tests harder. We describe how players and the gamemaster can spend and acquire these points later in this chapter.

Example: *The gamemaster determines that for Kara to make the trade deal with the spice merchant, she needs to use her Communicate skill. This is mainly as they are in an informal setting at a party. Were it a board room negotiation, Discipline or perhaps even Battle might have been another option.*

Next, Kara's player looks at her drive statements. Kara has three statements:

- ☞ **Duty:** "I am the heir of my House."
- ☞ **Faith:** "My family trusts me."
- ☞ **Power:** "I get what I want."

As Kara is negotiating on behalf of her House, her Duty statement seems the most appropriate. Her Faith statement might also apply, but as she is not

with her family at this soiree it isn't quite right. If she were negotiating for herself and not her House, her Power statement might be the one to use.

Next, Kara's player and the gamemaster must decide if the task is at odds with the drive statement. In this case it is not, as Kara is negotiating as the heir of her House. However, had this negotiation been a minor trade issue that could have been left to an underling, her drive statement might have been at odds with the task.

CHOOSING DRIVES

It can be difficult to decide which drive is the most appropriate, but just as difficult to pick when none of your drive statements seem to fit the situation. The following guidelines should help you make that decision.

If you have exactly the right drive statement...

Great! Pick that drive and carry on.

If several drive statements suit the action...

Here you can pick from whichever you prefer (usually the highest), but consider how your character is deciding to approach the action defined by the drive you choose. If it feels more 'in character' to pick a lower rated drive, that's great too.

If none of the drive statements suit the action...

Sometimes there just isn't a drive or statement that fits. In which case, you should choose one of your two lower drives that don't have a statement. This represents the character attaching no real focus to the task as it doesn't mean as much to them.

If the most appropriate drive statement is one that opposes the action...

In this case you can choose to challenge the drive. The gamemaster may offer a point of Determination. If you take it, you delete the opposing statement after making the test. The character has chosen to act against their drives and must rethink their values. This is a way for you to change your character's drives if they are not suiting the way you are playing them.

If you know what drive seems appropriate but the statement doesn't fit...

Here you might comply with the drive and gain a point of Determination, picking the drive you think is most appropriate, even though the statement doesn't quite fit. Your character considers the action at odds with their drives, but not enough to make them question their ideals. They can continue to make the test and keep their drive statement but pick up a Complication to represent how unsettled they are.

SKILL TEST PROCEDURE

When attempting a skill test, follow the procedure below:

1. The gamemaster usually selects one skill to be used, then the player should pick one drive they think is appropriate, guided by their drive statements. They may also select an applicable focus if they have one. These are added together to become the **target number**.
2. The gamemaster sets the **Difficulty** for the skill test; this is normally between 1 and 5, but it can be higher. Some skill tests may have a default Difficulty listed in the rules, but **traits**, **Threat**, and other factors can increase or decrease Difficulties. The Difficulty is the number of **successes** you must generate to pass the skill test.
3. The players and gamemaster should also finalize any traits they are applying (some might be required to even make it possible) before moving on to roll the dice.
4. You take two d20s, plus any additional d20s you've bought for this skill test. This is your dice pool for this skill test. Then, roll your dice pool.
5. Each d20 that rolls equal to or less than the target number scores a **single** success. Each die that rolls a 1 is a **critical success**, which scores two successes instead of one.
 - a. If a **focus** applies, then each die that rolls equal to or less than the skill being used scores a critical success.
 - b. Each die that rolls a 20 causes a **complication**.
4. If the number of successes scored equals or exceeds the Difficulty of the skill test, then you have passed. If the number of successes scored is less than the Difficulty of the skill test, then you have failed.
 - a. If the number of successes scored is greater than the Difficulty, each success above the Difficulty becomes a single point of **Momentum**.
5. The gamemaster describes the outcome of the skill test, and if the skill test was successful you may spend Momentum to improve the result further. After this, the effects of any complications are applied.

Example: Kara's player and the gamemaster have determined that the test to convince the merchant to make a deal should be *Communicate + Duty*, and that Kara can apply her 'Diplomacy' focus to the roll.



The Difficulty would normally be 2, but the gamemaster reduces this to 1 as Kara has the trait Honorable.

With a Communicate of 6 and a Duty of 7, Kara's player must roll 13 ($6+7=13$) or less to gain a success. Any die that rolls 6 or less count as two successes, because of the focus. If no focus applied, Kara's player would need to roll a 1 to gain two successes.

Kara's player has 2d20 to roll for the test, and no Momentum yet to buy any more. But as this is an important deal, she decides to give the gamemaster Threat so she can add another die, for a dice pool of 3d20.

She rolls 5, 14, and 20. The 5 grants two successes, the 14 grants nothing, and the 20 saddles Kara with a complication.

As Kara only needed one success (Difficulty 1), the roll is a success. She also gains 1 point of Momentum for getting one more success than she needed. The trade deal is completed in Kara's favor.

However, there is still a complication. The gamemaster suggests that Kara has been so busy negotiating she has failed to notice how often the servants have been filling her glass. She gains the temporary trait 'Intoxicated', which might cause problems if more negotiations must be done.

IMPROVING THE ODDS

While succeeding at most common tasks is a straightforward matter, even the most capable and driven character cannot succeed at the most challenging tasks without effort, opportunity, or assistance. To truly triumph, a character needs to find some other way of improving the odds.

Players have a number of ways to improve the odds: buying more d20s to roll, spending Determination, or getting assistance.

- ⊕ Momentum can be spent to buy additional dice before a skill test. You can buy up to three d20s for a skill test after the Difficulty has been declared, but before any dice are rolled. The first die you purchase for a skill test costs 1 point of Momentum, the second die costs 2 Momentum, and the third costs 3 Momentum (so buying an additional 2d20 costs 3 Momentum and an additional 3d20 costs 6 Momentum).
- ⊕ Threat can be generated to buy extra dice instead of spending Momentum. This works in the same way as spending Momentum, above, but you may generate Threat to pay some or all the cost, generating 1 point of Threat for each point of Momentum you would have spent.



- Determination ties into a character's drive statements, and has other uses, but it can be used to improve the odds. If the statement for the drive you're using on a skill test supports the action you're attempting, you may spend a point of Determination before rolling to change one of the dice so that it automatically rolls a 1, or after rolling to re-roll your entire dice pool. Determination and a character's drive statements are discussed above.
- Assistance is when another character actively assists your action. The gamemaster may limit how many characters may assist a given skill test. Each assistant selects a drive and skill to create a target number of their own, based on how they are helping, and rolls 1d20 (assistants cannot buy extra dice themselves). Any successes they generate are added to the skill test you are attempting, so long as you score at least one success of your own. Any complications from anyone involved in the skill test apply to everyone.

Example: Having completed her trade agreement in principle with the spice merchant, Kara can enjoy the rest of the party. Unfortunately, she notices that her old enemy Marcus Tarin, a courtier from a rival House, is also in attendance. Kara decides to chat with some of the other guests to see if anyone else knows why Marcus has arrived and what he plans.

As Marcus wasn't expected, the gamemaster decides learning anything is a Difficulty 3 test, not a result Kara's player believes she can roll easily on 2d20. Kara has a point of Momentum from her trade negotiations to buy another d20, and she decides to give the gamemaster Threat to get another one. This brings her dice pool up to 4d20.

While that should be enough, Kara can also enlist the help of Anna, her handmaiden. Anna sees what she can learn from the other servants. She makes a skill test of her own using only 1d20, but any successes she gets are added to Kara's total.

RECOVERING DRIVES

If any of your character's drive statements are crossed out, then they are less certain of their drives, and of their place in the universe. It takes time, reflection, and counsel to clear away that uncertainty.

At the end of any scene during which your character contemplated personal matters or discussed them with another character, and you did not spend or gain any Determination during that scene, you may ask the gamemaster to allow your character to recover a drive. If you don't do this during play, it happens automatically between adventures, should no suitable opportunities arise.

When your character recovers a drive, select a single drive which has had the statement crossed out, and do one of the following:

- **New Statement:** Create a new statement for that drive, which should in some way reflect your character's changed views and perspectives.
- **Changing Priorities:** Modify the score of that drive by -1 and choose the drive with the next lowest score to increase by +1 (so, if you're reducing a drive with a score of 6, you would increase the one which had a score of 5). If this would mean that the drive is reduced to less than 6, then it no longer has a statement (and similarly, any drive increased to 6 gains a statement). If this doesn't reduce the drive's score to 5, then the statement may remain unchanged (and no longer crossed-out).

Whichever option is chosen, the drive is now recovered and may be used freely, though you cannot challenge a drive which has already been challenged and recovered during that adventure (people's core drives do not change that often).

MOMENTUM

Whenever you score more successes than you needed on a skill test, each extra success becomes **Momentum**, which you can spend to improve the outcome of the skill test you've just passed. Any Momentum you don't spend can be saved, and saved Momentum goes into a group pool for everyone to use. Up to 6 points of Momentum can be saved like this. Momentum can be used for several things, including getting extra information about a situation, creating or changing traits in the scene, or buying extra dice for skill tests.

SPENDING MOMENTUM

You can spend Momentum to improve the outcome of a skill test you have passed, such as gaining more information or creating a lasting effect.

After a skill test has passed, the gamemaster describes what happens. You can then spend Momentum to improve this outcome, gain other benefits, or generally make the situation better for you and your allies, or worse for your opponents.

Momentum that you use in this way doesn't need to be declared in advance, and each point can be spent one at a time as needed. For example, if you spend Momentum to get more information from the gamemaster, you can wait to see what that information is before you decide what to do with the rest of the Momentum, so you don't waste Momentum by using it unnecessarily.

Unless otherwise noted, each use of Momentum—often called Momentum spends—can only be used once on any single skill test. Some uses of Momentum can be used multiple times, or their effect is 'per point of Momentum spent'. These options can be used as many times as you wish.

Once a skill test has been resolved, any unspent Momentum is saved into the group pool, as described below. Momentum that can't be added to the group pool—because the group pool is already full, or because it was bonus Momentum—is lost if it isn't spent.

Example: Kara's test to learn more about what Marcus might be up to goes very well, yielding 4 successes. She passes the test and gains 1 point of Momentum.

The gamemaster tells her that officially Marcus is here to make a spice deal, but many suspect he may have another motive. Kara can spend her bonus point of Momentum to ask a further question. Fearing Marcus may be looking to offer a deal to the same spice merchant, she considers asking who he might be making a deal with. However, she knows Marcus is also known to be a skilled assassin, so instead she asks, "Is he here to kill someone?"

The gamemaster replies "Probably", leaving Kara to wonder who the target might be—her spice merchant, or even herself! If only she had another point of Momentum to ask another question...

BONUS MOMENTUM

Some assets and talents grant a character bonus Momentum to successful skill tests, under specific circumstances. This is added to the amount of Momentum the character generates when they succeed at a skill test. Something which grants bonus Momentum may specify that it can only be used in specific ways.

Bonus Momentum differs from normal Momentum in that it cannot be saved into the group pool: if it is not used, then it is lost.

SAVING MOMENTUM

Saved Momentum goes into a group collection called the **Momentum pool**, also referred to as the group pool. Momentum in this pool can be used by anyone in the group, representing the benefits of prior successes and collective effort. **The Momentum pool cannot contain more than 6 Momentum points at any time.**

Whenever you wish to spend Momentum, you may spend from the group pool in addition to or instead of any Momentum you've generated yourself on a skill test. As normal, you don't have to choose how you're spending Momentum in advance, so you don't need to choose how much to take from the group pool until after you've decided how to spend it, and you don't need to spend it all at once.

At the end of a scene, 1 point of Momentum from the group pool is lost. Momentum needs to be maintained, and it does not last forever, so it's in your interests to spend it rather than saving it up.

TIMING MOMENTUM

The majority of uses of Momentum come immediately after a successful skill test, to improve the outcome of that skill test. However, a few important uses for Momentum happen spontaneously during play. These options have their own restrictions on how and when they are used, which is made clear in their text. Buying extra d20s is the most common example of this.

COMMON USES

You're encouraged to be creative in your uses of Momentum. When you pass a skill test and generate Momentum, think of how your superb performance might be reflected in the outcome, or how it might influence what happens next.

However, there are a few common Momentum spends which are key to how the system works and which serve as examples for what you can do with Momentum.

Regardless of how you use it, Momentum must make a degree of sense in the story—the benefit you've gained from Momentum must make sense from the perspective of the characters—and the gamemaster can veto any uses of Momentum that don't fit with the story or the scene.

- ✧ **Buying d20s** is one of the most common uses for Momentum. This is done before you roll the dice pool, but after the gamemaster decides on the Difficulty. The cost increases for each die purchased: the first die costs 1 point of Momentum, the second costs 2 Momentum, and the third costs 3. No more than three bonus d20s may be bought for a single skill test. As noted in **Improving the Odds** (p.149), you may pay for some or all this cost by adding to **Threat** instead of spending Momentum.
- ✧ **Create a Trait** allows you to define a new fact about the scene or situation. Spending 2 points of Momentum either creates a brand-new trait, changes an existing one, or removes one currently in play. When you create a trait, it must relate to the action you've just attempted, and it must be something that could reasonably result from that action.

✧ **Create an Asset** works in the same way as creating a trait, but there are some limitations to the kinds of assets you can create. An asset created has a Quality of 0, and it should be useful in the current type of conflict. Assets created in this way are temporary and cease to exist at the end of the scene. Whatever the asset represents is discarded or ceases to be useful. You may spend 2 Momentum to make an Asset created during a scene permanent (at Quality 0) in which case it is added to the list of assets on your character sheet.

✧ **Obtain Information** allows you to learn more about the scene and situation. Each point of Momentum you spend allows you to ask the gamemaster one question about the current situation. The gamemaster must answer this question truthfully, but the answer doesn't need to be complete: partial or incomplete answers that leave room for further questions are more common. The answers must reflect the skill you've used to gain the information, and it should be something that your character would be able to determine themselves. "You don't know" or "You can't tell" are valid answers from the gamemaster, but the gamemaster **must** refund any Momentum spent if they give answers like that.

Example: So far, Kara has used Momentum to buy extra d20s and to Obtain Information by asking about Marcus' secret mission.

If she had more Momentum she might ask more questions. However, she could still create a new trait such as 'Inquisitive' that might give her a bonus to further investigations.



COMPLICATIONS

When you attempt a skill test, any dice which roll a 20 cause a **complication**. This doesn't mean you've failed—you can suffer complications and still succeed if you get enough successes—but each complication does create an extra problem, and may be inconvenient, painful, or embarrassing.

Things don't always go to plan, and while you may succeed at what you set out to achieve, there may be bumps along that road. When you roll a skill test, any die that rolls a 20 causes a **complication**, which takes effect once the skill test has been resolved. Complications don't stop you from succeeding, but they may impede your actions later or have other repercussions.

The gamemaster can use a complication to inflict an immediate problem upon your character or the situation, which should relate in some way to the action you've just performed. This can often create a **trait**—a fact about the scene—which hinders or impairs your actions, by increasing the Difficulty of skill tests or making some actions impossible. These traits may be persistent problems, or they may be short-lived, lasting only long enough to affect the character's next skill test.

There are other ways for the gamemaster to use complications, however. A useful alternative is to impose some immediate restriction or penalty, limiting a character's immediate choices by prohibiting an action they could normally take. A complication might instead cause an activity to take longer than normal (as a rule of thumb, each complication increases the time taken by 50%). In general, a complication can work like a negative trait. It can stop you from doing something you would usually be able to, or increase the Difficulty of an action by 1.

You are not powerless in this situation, though. When you suffer a complication, you may choose to buy it off by adding 2 points of **Threat** to the gamemaster's pool—in essence, avoiding a problem now in return for potential problems later. The gamemaster may also trade a complication you or another player has rolled for 2 points of Threat if they don't wish to create an immediate problem or simply can't think of one right now. If a non-player character suffers a complication, the gamemaster can buy it off by spending 2 points of Threat.

EXAMPLE COMPLICATIONS

As complications are tied to a specific skill, the following are grouped by skill only to suggest what sort of tests might result in particular complications.

EXAMPLE BATTLE COMPLICATIONS

- ✶ **Bruised:** The pain is making it hard to concentrate.
- ✶ **Exhausted:** I'm too tired to fight.
- ✶ **Flanked:** I'm in a tactically bad position.
- ✶ **Injured:** I have suffered an injury to <area>.
- ✶ **Stunned:** I'm dazed from a strike.
- ✶ **Unarmed:** I've lost my weapon.

EXAMPLE COMMUNICATE COMPLICATIONS

- ✶ **Disconnected:** I am out of my depth in this social situation.
- ✶ **Gauche:** I am showing off my status too much.
- ✶ **Inferior:** My lack of status has been exposed.
- ✶ **Outsider:** I don't really fit in here.
- ✶ **Rude:** I have caused offense.
- ✶ **Tongue-tied:** I can't seem to get the right words out.

EXAMPLE DISCIPLINE COMPLICATIONS

- ✶ **Angry:** I am too full of rage for anything but action.
- ✶ **Conflicted:** I am torn between possibilities.
- ✶ **Distracted:** There is too much going on.
- ✶ **Frightened:** I can't deal with this.
- ✶ **Intoxicated:** I've had too much to drink.
- ✶ **Unfocused:** I can't seem to concentrate.

EXAMPLE MOVE COMPLICATIONS

- ✶ **Awkward:** I have no grace or flow of movement.
- ✶ **Constricted:** There isn't enough room for me to move.
- ✶ **Hurt:** An injury is slowing me down.
- ✶ **Slow:** I can't move very quickly.
- ✶ **Tired:** I am feeling too exhausted to run.
- ✶ **Uncoordinated:** I can't seem to control my movements.

EXAMPLE UNDERSTAND COMPLICATIONS

- ✶ **Complicated:** There are too many connections to see an answer.
- ✶ **Confused:** I don't quite understand what is going on.
- ✶ **Misinformed:** Some of my data is wrong.
- ✶ **Overthinking:** The answer just cannot be that simple.
- ✶ **Uninformed:** I am missing a vital piece of information.
- ✶ **Vague:** I am having trouble thinking.

Example: Kara has already picked up the complication 'Intoxicated' that has been adding to the Difficulty of her tests. As this is a social scene, further complications would relate to that. She might make a fool of herself in some way (such as spilling something on the wrong person) or fail to remember a point of etiquette and gain further complications like 'Clumsy' or 'Rude'.

If the situation with Marcus becomes physical, she might gain complications representing wounds, or even that she has been poisoned.

COMPLICATION RANGE

Some situations can make a skill test uncertain, rather than more difficult. These factors make it more likely that complications occur, by increasing the range of numbers which cause complications. A test has a **complication range** of 1 normally, so complications occur on any die that rolls a 20 (only a 1 in 20 chance per die). The complication range can never be increased to more than five, and the effect of changing the complication range is explained on the table below:

COMP. RANGE	DESCRIPTION	COMP. OCCUR ON...
1	Normal	20
2	Risky	19 or 20
3	Perilous	18–20
4	Precarious	17–20
5	Treacherous	16–20

SUCCESS AT A COST

Some skill tests can't really be failed outright. Sometimes an action will inevitably succeed, but there might be problems or consequences along the way. In these situations, the gamemaster may allow a skill test to **succeed at a cost**, either before the dice have rolled, or after the result is known. If a skill test succeeds at a cost, then a character who fails a skill test still achieves their goal in some form, but they also suffer one or more automatic complications, in addition to any they're suffering because of the roll. The gamemaster determines how many extra complications are suffered.

Although the failed skill test has produced a successful outcome, Momentum cannot be spent to improve the result of a skill test that succeeded at a cost: Momentum can only be spent if a skill test was passed.

The gamemaster may declare that an action succeeds at a cost, or they may give a player a choice to succeed at a cost. This choice can and should be made on a case-by-case basis according to the situation.

Example: Kara attempts to make another test to learn more from the gathering before confronting Marcus. However, she fails to get the required successes. The gamemaster allows her to succeed at a cost. For succeeding at the test she learns the spice merchant is indeed Marcus' target. However, the cost is that Marcus becomes aware Kara is asking questions about him and now knows his plan.



THREAT

Where you and the other players have Momentum, the gamemaster has **Threat**. Threat works much the same as Momentum, but for your opponents and enemies. Threat can be used for the same things as Momentum, but the gamemaster can also use Threat to alter situations or the story in a few special ways. Threat represents perils, unforeseen dangers, and the potential for drama and excitement, and it rises and falls during play. In addition to this, if you're low on Momentum, you can buy extra dice by adding to Threat, essentially taking risks to get an advantage.

As player characters generate and spend Momentum, the gamemaster generates and spends their own resource: **Threat**. The gamemaster makes use of Threat to alter scenes, empower non-player characters, and generally make things challenging, perilous, or unpredictable for the player characters. Threat is a method by which the game, and the gamemaster, builds tension: the larger the Threat pool, the greater the likelihood that something endangers or threatens the player characters. In this way, Threat mimics the rise and fall of tension that builds throughout a story, eventually culminating in a high-tension finale. Strictly speaking, characters don't know about Threat, but they have a sense of the stakes of their current situation, and the potential for things to go wrong.

The gamemaster typically begins each adventure with two points of Threat for each player present at the start of the adventure, though this can be adjusted based on the tone and underlying tension of a given adventure: if the stakes are high, the gamemaster may begin with more Threat, while a calmer, quieter situation may reduce the gamemaster's starting Threat. Part of this is defined by the size of the player characters' House: a powerful House invites challenge and breeds enemies and rivalries, and this is represented by larger amounts of starting Threat.

ADDING TO THREAT

Player characters can add to the Threat pool in the following ways:

- ❖ **Buying d20s:** As noted earlier in this chapter, characters may buy bonus d20s for skill tests by adding points to Threat instead of spending Momentum. As normal, no more than three dice can be bought, and the cost increases for each dice: the first costs 1, the second costs 2, and the third costs 3.
- ❖ **Complications:** Whenever a player character suffers one or more complications on a skill test, they or the gamemaster may choose to add two points to the Threat pool to ignore a complication. This may be done for as many or as few complications as desired.
- ❖ **Escalation:** At times, the gamemaster (or the rules) may state that a specific action or decision risks escalating the situation, making it more dangerous or unpredictable. If a character performs an action that risks escalation, they immediately add one point of Threat to the pool.

The gamemaster may add to Threat in the following ways:

- ❖ **Threatening Circumstances:** The environment or circumstances of a new scene may be threatening or perilous enough to warrant adding one or two points of Threat to the pool automatically. Similarly, some non-player characters may generate Threat simply by arriving, in response to changes in the situation, or by taking certain actions. This also includes activities that escalate the tensions of the scene, such as non-player characters raising an alarm.
- ❖ **Non-player Character Momentum:** Non-player characters with unspent Momentum cannot save it as player characters can, as they don't have a group Momentum pool. Instead, a non-player character may add to Threat, adding one point of Threat for every Momentum they have remaining.

***Example:** Realizing the stakes have increased, Kara's player decides to shake off the Intoxicated complication, adding 2 points of Threat to the gamemaster's*

pool. The gamemaster also decides to add another point of *Threat* to their pool, given that Marcus is now looking to either silence Kara or at least ensure she doesn't interfere.

SPENDING THREAT

The gamemaster can spend *Threat* in several common ways:

- **Buying d20s:** The gamemaster can purchase d20s for a skill test attempted by one of their non-player characters. The cost of this increases for each die purchased: the first die costs 1 point of *Threat*, the second costs 2 *Threat*, and the third costs 3. No more than three bonus d20s may be bought for a single skill test, regardless of the source.
- **Increase Difficulty:** The gamemaster can choose to make things more difficult for a character, increasing the Difficulty of a single skill test by one for every 2 points of *Threat* spent. The decision to increase a skill test's Difficulty must be made before any dice are bought or rolled on that skill test.
- **Non-player Character Threat Spends:** When a player character's action would normally add points to *Threat*, a non-player character performing that same action, or making the same choice, must spend an equivalent number of points of *Threat*.
- **Non-player Character Complications:** If a non-player character suffers a complication, the gamemaster may buy off that complication by spending two points of *Threat*.
- **Traits:** The gamemaster may change, remove, or create a trait by spending two points of *Threat*. This must come naturally from some part of the current situation.
- **Environmental Effects and Narrative Changes:** The gamemaster may trigger or cause problems with the scene or environment by spending *Threat*.
- **Rival House Action:** The gamemaster may spend a *Threat* point to introduce a known enemy House to the situation. It may be one of their agents simply taking an opportunity to attack the player characters, or it may turn out that they have an alliance with whomever the player characters are dealing with. Either way, the House makes an appearance in some way to complicate the situation for the player characters.

Example: As the situation is heating up, the gamemaster decides to spend some of their *Threat*. They decide that Marcus has a lot of friends at the party who have become irked at Kara's questioning. The gamemaster spends a point of *Threat* to add the environmental effect 'Hostile Room'.



DETERMINATION

Determination is a special, scarce resource which you can spend on skill tests which align with your character's drives. It is earned when a character's drives impede or hinder their actions. You can spend Determination before rolling to set a die so that it counts as having rolled a 1, or after rolling to re-roll an entire dice pool, or to create, destroy, or change a trait, or to take extra actions in a conflict.

A character's drives are a vital part of their successes and their failures. Conviction and clarity of purpose, and a potent sense of self, are key parts of why a character takes the actions they do. To this end, all player characters, and many non-player characters, have **drive statements** which reflect the character's personal values and guiding principles. When a character's actions align with these principles, they can be spurred on to greater heights of success, but when a character attempts actions which clash with their values, it can cause them considerable problems.

At the start of each adventure, you have a single point of Determination for your character, but you may gain more during play. You may never have more than three Determination at once.

When you attempt a skill test, and the drive you are using has a drive statement, both you and the gamemaster should consider whether the statement and the action you're attempting align. If the statement supports the action—that is, if the statement would be an advantage to the action being attempted—then you can use that drive freely for that action, and you may spend a point of Determination to gain one of the following benefits. Some talents or other character abilities may grant them additional ways to use Determination.

- ❖ **Automatic 1:** Before rolling, choose one of the d20s in your dice pool: that die is considered to have rolled a 1, and does not need to be rolled. It thus scores a critical success automatically.
- ❖ **Re-roll:** After rolling, re-roll any number of d20s in your dice pool.
- ❖ **Declaration:** Before or after rolling, create a new trait, or change or remove an existing one; this must relate to your character, but it may represent something which was always true, but which has only now been revealed or become important. You may retroactively describe how this trait came to be.
- ❖ **Extra Action:** In a **conflict**, immediately take an additional action after this one, even if you have already kept the initiative.

However, if the statement would conflict with the action—it may impair your character's judgment, make them biased, blind them to possibilities, or it may be that the action goes against your character's morals,

spiritual drives, or sense of honor—then the gamemaster can offer you a point of Determination to give you a choice: comply or challenge.

- ❖ If you **comply** with your drive, then you immediately suffer a complication (which may often make the action harder or prevent you from even attempting the action). The character's drives are too strong to allow them to carry out this action freely, causing a problem.
- ❖ If you **challenge** your drive, then you may act freely, but you must cross out that drive statement, and you may not use that drive score again until it has been recovered (see below). The character's need to act has outweighed their strongly held drives, and in the process, their worldview has been shaken.

You may refuse to accept the offered Determination to avoid making the choice, but if you do so, you must choose a different drive to use for the skill test. You may also suggest to the gamemaster moments where your drives may conflict with your actions, though both you and the gamemaster must agree for this to happen.

THAT'S A LOT OF DIFFERENT POINTS

Momentum, Threat, and Determination have a variety of different effects, and it might seem like a lot of points to keep track of as you make rolls.

But in the 2d20 system, how you spend these points is often far more important than what dice you roll. They grant both players and gamemaster a lot of control over their dice and represent the characters marshalling their resources before making their play. This makes knowing what to spend on which test an important skill to master. Do you put everything into the current test or save something for later? How important is it to succeed, and can you afford the cost? All these factors must be decided before you roll anything. This means any roll of the dice is a carefully considered plan of action, never just the whim of fate.

CONTESTS

In a contest, the character opposing you rolls first, and their number of successes becomes the Difficulty you need to roll against. Once they've rolled, you roll to see if you can beat them.

When the actions you want to attempt are actively opposed by another, a skill test becomes a contest. In a contest, the opposing character first rolls to set the Difficulty. They gather a dice pool, rolling against their own target number as if they were attempting a skill test. The total number of successes they score becomes the Difficulty for your skill test.

At this point, you make your skill test as normal, rolling against that Difficulty.

If you succeed, then you achieve your desired goal, and can spend any Momentum you generate to improve that outcome as normal. If you fail, the opposing character generates 1 point of Momentum for each success fewer than the Difficulty which you scored—i.e., if the Difficulty was 4, and you scored two successes, the opposing character would get 2 points of Momentum—and they may spend this Momentum immediately, as if they had succeeded at a skill test.

After all this has been resolved, any complications suffered by either side are handled by the gamemaster.

Example: Given that Marcus is a highly skilled assassin, Kara cannot let him get close to the spice trader, who is chatting amiably nearby to another noble, utterly unaware of the danger he is in. She could try and physically confront Marcus but that may go poorly. However, she might be able to intimidate him into leaving, given that she knows his intentions and has a vested interest in keeping the spice trader alive.

Kara finds a quiet part of the ballroom to take Marcus aside. Luckily, he makes no attempt to avoid a confrontation as he wants to know what Kara is up to. Kara explains that she knows his plan and tells him that the spice trader is under her protection, as they have a deal. Assassinating him may start a new conflict between their Houses.

This is a *Communicate* test, with Kara using her *Power* drive with the statement 'I get what I want'. As this challenge is very much in line with her drive statement, the gamemaster allows Kara's player to spend *Determination* on the test.

The gamemaster rolls for Marcus first to set the stakes, as he is the defending party. The gamemaster spends some *Threat* and manages to get 4 successes. This means Kara needs to roll 4 successes to win the contest.

Kara must overcome the additional Difficulty of a hostile environment, as Marcus knows he has several

allies to back him up. This raises the Difficulty to 5, but luckily Kara has bought off her complication so it doesn't get any worse.

However, she needs to call upon all her resources. She gives the gamemaster enough *Threat* to buy 2 more dice and brings her handmaiden Anna in to support her with assistance. This gives her a dice pool of 4 with bonus successes if Anna rolls well with her single die.

The roll is not very good, yielding 2 successes, not nearly enough. As the stakes are high, Kara's player opts to spend her *Determination* to re-roll some of the dice. Two of her dice offered a success each, and while she could re-roll those in the hope of getting a better result, she decides not to risk it. She re-rolls the two other dice, the ones that yielded no successes. Anna's assistance roll was also a failure, but as it isn't part of Kara's dice pool it cannot be re-rolled with the *Determination* spend.

Thankfully, the two re-rolled dice both come up a success, and one of them even rolls a 1. This adds another 3 successes to the existing 2, taking the total to the five successes required.

Marcus takes a moment to weigh up his options. He decides that the risk of a *House on House* conflict is not what his masters are interested in. He chooses to take Kara seriously and withdraws to confer with his superiors. With a small bow he smiles at Kara and tells her he looks forward to their next encounter, then leaves.

EXTERNAL FACTORS IN CONTESTS

The procedure for contests assumes that both sides are on roughly equal footing, and that neither side has any real advantages or hindrances beyond their own abilities. This isn't always the case.

If the opposing character has any factors—such as traits—which would make things harder for them, each such factor reduces the Difficulty they set by 1, to a minimum of 0. In essence, fewer of their successes translate into Difficulty for their opponent.

If the active character has any factors which would affect the Difficulty of their action other than the opposing character, then adjust the final Difficulty up or down as normal.

In either case, characters in a contest may accept assistance from other characters on their side.

Example: In Kara and Marcus' contest the environment was working to Marcus' advantage. Had they been among Kara's allies the circumstances would have been different. Had time been a factor for either party, that too could have made their position trickier.

EXTENDED TASKS

Some activities may take a while to complete, requiring ongoing effort over a prolonged period. This is especially useful when an ongoing action can be interrupted or cannot be completed all in one go.

These extended tasks occur entirely at the gamemaster's discretion and can be used for a wide range of situations. When the gamemaster decides that a situation is an extended task—and this can be something caused during play, perhaps by spending Threat point or because of a complication—they choose how big the extended task is. This is called the requirement. Each passed skill test made toward completing an extended task scores one or more points, and when a total number of points have been scored equal to the **requirement**, then the extended task is complete, and whatever event or activity the task represented is resolved.

As a rule of thumb, each passed skill test should score 2 points towards the requirement, which can be reduced by complications and increased by spending Momentum. If an extended task is based on overcoming something set in place by an opponent, then using one of their skill ratings is a good basis for the task's requirement. In either case, appropriate traits may increase these scores further. If an asset has a Quality rating of 1 or above, this also adds to the points scored towards the requirement.

Extended tasks can also be presented from the opposite direction to represent impending problems, with failed skill tests, complications, or perilous actions **adding** points, and the problem occurring when the requirement is met. Situations may have both an extended task for you to work toward, and one representing a problem, with one or other increasing depending on whether skill tests were passed or not.

Example: Her behavior at the party has not done Kara's reputation any good. She has upset a few of the guests with her questions, and possibly embarrassed herself by drinking too much. She also clearly had a conflict of some form with Marcus, who has many friends at the gathering. Kara's player asks the gamemaster if there is anything Kara can do to repair her reputation, so it doesn't suffer any damage when people talk of how the evening went.

The gamemaster decides this is an extended task, with a requirement of 5 to settle any of the other guests' ruffled feathers. However, the party will eventually end, meaning Kara has a limited amount of time to perform the task.

The gamemaster decides Kara can only make three rolls before the party ends—there's only so much effort she can make to fix this. The first test makes decent progress, succeeding and scoring 2 points toward the requirement. On the second test, she struggles to assuage the partygoers' concerns, succeeding but suffering a complication, which means she only scores 1 point. On the third attempt, she succeeds—scoring the last two points she needed—and even generates some Momentum, which she saves for later, as it's not needed here. While it takes her the rest of the night, she manages to talk to all the guests and assure them that Marcus simply felt ill and had to retire. While it is exhausting, she finally leaves the party having made a new deal, beaten a deadly enemy, and maintained the reputation of herself and her House. All in all, quite a good evening.







CHAPTER 6: CONFLICT

*Arrakis teaches the attitude of the knife—chopping off what's incomplete and saying:
Now, it's complete because it's ended here.*

*—from *Collected Sayings of Muad'Dib*, by the Princess Irulan*

THE NATURE OF CONFLICT



Conflict is inevitable in the Imperium. The interplay of wealth, power, influence, politics, greed, and ambition that forms most interactions between the Houses of the Landsraad, CHOAM, the Imperial Court, the Spacing Guild, the Bene Gesserit, and other factions, breeds strife and turmoil. This creates opportunities to exploit and crises to overcome, and the fortunes of any House, or any person, rise and fall with how they face the conflicts ahead of them.

Conflicts add an additional layer to gameplay, and are used to provide greater detail to specific situations when desired. This does mean they add more complexity to the game, so they should be used sparingly and only in situations where the benefits of including them outweigh the extra effort involved.

Conflict covers a multitude of different forms of contest, from physical fights to intrigue and assassination. These rules assume a few concepts that differ from many other roleplaying games, and allow us to use the same system to cover a multitude of conflict styles.

- ✧ Conflict is not just physical combat, and any method to defeat an enemy with any tool can be a conflict.
- ✧ The ability and skill of each combatant is more important than the actual weapons used. A knife kills as well as a sword, although different weapons can provoke different advantages in different situations. These advantages are managed by applying traits.

- ✧ Each test in a conflict is an encounter and an exchange of blows or political moves, and does not represent a single thrust of a blade. Conflict is swift and deadly, in some cases resolved with a single dice test.
- ✧ Assets are often essential to allow the conflict to occur at all. While a fighter might choose to engage a foe unarmed, it is impossible to blackmail someone without something to blackmail them with. So, an asset or trait may often be required to make the conflict possible.
- ✧ Conflicts do not need to cause wounds or physically hurt a target. Many things might lead to their defeat, such as exhaustion, lack of resources, or losing allies or the respect of their peers. An enemy can be defeated without a drop of blood being shed.
- ✧ Complications suffered during a conflict represent actual hurt combatants suffer. They make winning more difficult but who got hurt the most doesn't define victory.
- ✧ Defeat does not mean death. While it often does in **Dune**, enemies can yield, be exiled, knocked out, or be stripped of resources.

CONFLICT SCOPE

Conflicts take many different forms, and they can occur on many different scales. The following forms of common conflict are discussed in more detail in these rules. But new forms of conflict can easily be initiated with the general system:



- ✧ **Dueling** is physical conflict between individuals, using hand-held weapons like swords and daggers, envenomed needles, and similar close-quarters tools. Personal shields—either full-body or partial—are common in dueling, making ranged weapons mostly ineffective, and lasguns of any kind a desperate proposition. Dueling can take the form of formalized dueling, assassination attempts, gladiatorial bouts, and one-on-one combat.
- ✧ **Skirmishes** are similar to dueling, and employ a similar range of tools, but involve a handful of combatants on each side. A skirmish may make use of ranged weapons in a way that dueling does not, particularly if the conflict starts when attempting to ambush unshielded foes. Skirmishes still take place over a relatively short range, but are close enough that a swordmaster is still able to put their prowess to good use.
- ✧ **Warfare** is physical combat on a strategic level, involving groups of armed personnel such as House troops, mercenaries, or even the Emperor's deadly Sardaukar. Outright warfare between Major Houses is rare and highly regulated, in part because most factions must rely on the Spacing Guild to move anything from world to world, and the Guild may refuse to support actions that they do not regard as worthwhile. Amongst the Minor Houses on a single world, however, warfare may be as common or uncommon as the ruling Major House allows—some Major Houses encourage strife between their subordinates to weed out the weak, while others prefer different methods of resolving tensions.

- ✧ **Espionage** is conflict relying on stealth and deception to gain access to a secure location or important person, normally to obtain information, steal valuable items, or perform assassinations. Espionage can easily turn into another form of conflict if performed poorly, but it can also negate the need for other, more overt forms of conflict if performed well. Espionage is primarily performed by spies, informants, and surveillance devices, and countered by guards, security systems, and methods of ensuring loyalty or rooting out deception, such as Truthsayers. Mentats, and Bene Gesserit sisters are often exceptionally valuable in both espionage and counterespionage.
- ✧ **Intrigue** is social conflict where secrets and individual agendas are most prominent. Participants often seek to discover what others know or what they desire, while keeping their own goals and their own secrets hidden. Intrigue can take place over a long period of time, or it can be focused on a single localized event. It occurs most regularly where society's expectations and cultural taboos would prevent more overt forms of conflict. Intrigue often overlaps with espionage. Achieving goals through intrigue and influence is often regarded as 'soft power', as a counterpoint to the 'hard power' of direct authority, force, and military might.

Each of these forms of conflict are described in more detail in their own sections, later in this chapter.



THE BASICS OF CONFLICT

All conflicts have similarities. At their core, conflicts arise when two or more opposing parties have goals which are at odds with one another, and the conflict itself occurs as a means to resolve that tension. Each side in a conflict has a collection of tools and resources—collectively referred to as **assets**—which they can employ. It isn't enough to merely have a tool, however: one must be able to wield it effectively, maneuvering their own assets to harm their opponents or protect themselves from their opponents' actions.

This section describes the ways that conflicts in **Dune** are similar. Later sections describe the specifics of how these common elements differ (often in just a narrative sense) in different types of conflict.

ASSETS

Conflict revolves around the use of assets. An asset is anything which a character possesses or controls which they can use to protect themselves, overcome others, or otherwise achieve their goals. Each asset is useful in different circumstances, and can be used in a variety of ways: a company of House troops can be used during warfare to attack or defend, but they can also be used as guards to prevent infiltration during espionage, or in a parade to honor or awe a guest during negotiations or intrigue.

Assets are, by themselves, a form of trait, though specific assets may have additional rules associated with them in some contexts, such as to describe the destructive interaction between a lasgun and a shield. Each asset also notes the type or types of conflict they are most suited for. This is not a restriction, so much as a prompt: using an asset in an unconventional way in a type of conflict it isn't normally used for might be a winning strategy, but that sort of creativity is left to the gamemaster to resolve.

Assets broadly come in two forms: tangible and intangible.

A **tangible asset** is one that has a physical presence, and which has a degree of permanence to it: a weapon is a tangible asset, as is a unit of troops, a surveillance system, or a quantity of material goods. Tangible assets are normally owned by individual characters or by the House. They're difficult to remove from play, and they are normally only removed temporarily.

An **intangible asset** is one that has no physical presence: a bribed guard, the leverage from having other potential trading partners, the mistaken drive of a foe fed false information, or newly obtained knowledge about a rival's weaknesses. Intangible assets are created by individual characters during play... but they're also easier to remove from play than tangible assets.

Assets also have a **Quality**, normally rated from 0 to 4. Most assets have a Quality of 0, with only special or elite

versions offering a bonus. The higher an asset's Quality, the more effective or impactful it is compared to other assets of a similar kind. A Fremen crysknife is more potent than a simple footpad's knife, elite professional soldiers are superior to an equivalent number of ill-trained conscripts, etc. Quality gives a guide to the quality of an asset among its peers, not compared to other assets. Quality is used in a few ways, described later in this chapter.

Example: Kara Molay has three personal assets: a concealable knife, her personal ornithopter, and some as-of-yet undetermined blackmail evidence. The knife and ornithopter are tangible assets, and the blackmail evidence is intangible. They are all Quality 0 but any of them might be upgraded with more study, honing, or skill. These are just her most useful possessions, though. She has access to all manner of other specialized equipment her House can provide, and as for normal items, no one in the Imperium is ever very far away from a knife.

ZONES OF CONFLICT

When a conflict begins, the gamemaster defines the area within which the conflict takes place. This may be a physical area or an abstract representation of the conflict, but in either case, it is divided into distinct **zones**, within which characters can move and use their assets. Zones can be any size or shape. A contest between two merchants might use two zones, each being a whole planet. A fight between some assassins in an alley might be a single zone, or even six different zones denoting different parts of the alley.

How these zones relate to one another (including how they're connected and how characters and assets move around them) is determined by the gamemaster as well. (More guidance accompanies each different style of conflict. Where possible, conflict involving dueling, skirmishes, warfare, and espionage should have clear links between zones, while negotiations and intrigue should have most/all zones 'free-floating' where they all count as adjacent to everything else.)

Some zones may have special effects (usually traits) which apply to assets or characters within them, or which are regarded as more or less important than others; a skirmish may have a zone which is full of hindering obstacles that make it harder to move, while a warfare conflict may denote particular zones as objectives which each side is eager to secure.

Sometimes a conflict might only occur in one zone. This might be because the area is small, or all the participants are forced into a more rigidly defined area. If your group finds zones confusing, it is perfectly permissible to place the conflict in a single zone until everyone is more comfortable with the rules of conflict.

ACTION ORDER

During a conflict, characters perform actions in a specific order. Each character takes a **turn**, during which they may take an **action**. Once each character in the conflict has taken a turn, a single **round** is completed, and a new round begins. This repeats until the conflict is concluded.

At the start of the first round, the gamemaster selects which character takes the first turn. This is normally a player character, unless there is a compelling narrative reason for a non-player character to take the first turn, or the gamemaster spends 2 points of Threat.

Once a character has finished their turn, they may do one of the following: either allow an opposing side to choose someone to act next, or spend 2 points of Momentum (or add 2 to Threat) to Keep the Initiative (enemy non-player characters may spend 2 points of Threat to do this). If they **Keep the Initiative**, then that character may take an extra action immediately, adding +1 Difficulty to any test they attempt, or allow an allied character to take a turn before handing over to an opposing side. Once a side has chosen to Keep the Initiative, they may not do so again until at least one enemy character has taken a turn of their own.

Each time a new character is chosen to act, the character chosen must be someone who has not yet taken a

turn during the current round. If there are no characters left on a side who haven't yet taken a turn, that side must pass and immediately nominate another opposing side. If only one side has characters remaining to act, then they each take a turn in sequence until all characters have taken a turn.

Once all characters have taken a turn, the round ends. The character who acted last must either nominate an opposing side to take the first turn in the next round, or spend 2 points of Momentum/add 2 to Threat (non-player characters spend 2 Threat) to allow their side to take the first turn next round.

Example: Kara and her friend Nasir are set upon by two assassins. As it is an ambush, the assassins start with the initiative. One of them makes an attack, and then the initiative passes to Kara and Nasir. The players decide Kara should be the one to act, and after she attacks, the initiative passes to the assassins. One assassin has already acted, so the other one must be the one to take a turn this time. However, before passing the initiative over, Kara and Nasir spend Momentum to Keep the Initiative. This allows Nasir to take an attack. But if they cannot fell the assassins, the remaining one can still take a turn before the round ends.



TAKING ACTION

When you take your turn, you may take a single action, to either **move** an asset or **use an asset**. You are welcome to suggest actions which aren't covered below, and the gamemaster determines how to resolve them (often by selecting which action is closest to what you've suggested and using it as a baseline).

MOVE

You move one of your assets (or your character, in some cases) from its current location to any adjacent zone. You may spend 2 points of Momentum to move your chosen asset one additional zone, or to choose a second asset to move one zone.

When you move, you gain an additional benefit, but there is a risk to this. You may attempt to move in a **subtle** way, trying to avoid attention, or you may move in a **bold** manner that provokes a response. In either case, this requires a skill test, with a Difficulty of 2. If you pass the skill test, you gain an additional benefit, listed below.

- ✧ If you move an asset **subtly**, your subtlety limits your opponents' ability to respond. If you pass, then you move your asset, and you reduce the cost to Keep the Initiative to 0: your subtlety allows you to act again before your enemy can react.
- ✧ If you move an asset **boldly**, you provoke a hasty response from your opponent. If you pass, then you move your asset, and then you may move one of an opposing character's assets: your daring play has provoked a reaction, just as you planned.

In either case, if you fail, you may not spend Momentum on additional movement, and one enemy may move a single asset one zone, as they react to your failed play. Further, if you fail, you may not Keep the Initiative.

Example: Kara and Nasir are both flying ornithopters to a secret facility run by their enemy, House Arcuri. As several security measures are in play, infiltrating the base becomes an espionage conflict. The gamemaster has divided the facility and its surroundings into zones that Kara and Nasir's ornithopters need to move into.

Kara goes first and moves subtly. She makes a successful test and moves her ornithopter into the next zone, but it is a zone occupied by an enemy 'thopter. She pays the cheaper price to Keep the Initiative, allowing Nasir to take an action before the enemy pilot.

Nasir moves boldly, flying close enough to get the attention of the enemy pilot. Nasir can move to another zone, but also moves the enemy ornithopter in Kara's zone to a different one. The enemy pilot takes the bait, following Nasir's ornithopter as Kara flies low toward the facility, unseen.

USE AN ASSET

You may choose one of the assets you control and use it to achieve some other goal. You must declare what you are doing with the asset, and what effect you wish your action to have.

Common examples of ways to use an asset include, but are not limited to:

- ✧ Attacking an opponent with the intent of harming or defeating them (see **Attacks, Defeat, and Recovery**).
- ✧ Attempting to remove an opponent's asset from play.
- ✧ Attempting to create a new trait for the scene, or a new asset for your character or an ally.
- ✧ Attempting to overcome an obstacle in the environment.
- ✧ Attempting to gain information about the situation.
- ✧ Attempting to remove a trait or similar complication from an ally, or to aid a defeated ally.

Regardless of the desired outcome, this action always requires a skill test. If you pass the test, then you get the desired effect. If you fail, then the action you've attempted is prevented, and you may not Keep the Initiative.

Actions which directly affect a specific opponent are **contests** rather than skill tests: the opponent gets to resist the action taken against them. The final Difficulty of a contest is influenced by the assets the defender has.

Some outcomes may not be possible to achieve in a single action. These turn into **extended tasks**, where the character makes progress toward their goal bit by bit over several actions. The requirement for the extended test is usually based on the defender's skill. The number of points made toward the requirement of the extended task is equal to 2 plus the Quality of the asset used: more potent assets make progress faster.

Remember that assets are simply additional traits you can use to modify the situation. However, in some cases they may be required to allow the conflict to occur at all.

Example: Nasir has an enemy pilot on his tail in the same zone, and he needs to defeat that pilot to escape. Flying in different vehicles makes it impossible for Nasir to take any action against the pilot himself. So, he must first declare he is using his ornithopter asset to make the conflict between them possible. The enemy pilot uses his ornithopter asset to make a defense possible.

Nasir may be able to apply other traits, just like any other contest, to get a better Difficulty rating. But having used his ornithopter to initiate the conflict, it cannot also adjust the Difficulty.